gain was at the expense of the Congress, but the AAP was turning out to be an emerging third force.

From Shah's demeanour, it was obvious that Kejriwal's rise was troubling the BJP's strategists. Kejriwal had almost wiped Modi off the front pages, but even more importantly, had become a talking point amongst the youth and the urban middle class, the core target groups of the BJP's 'Modi for PM' campaign. A dark, short, slightly built moustachioed Hissar-born man who till a year ago had been seen as little more than a political gadfly was now threatening to take on the BJP's Goliath. It was lightweight versus super heavyweight, but Kejriwal had made a career out of punching above his weight.

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I first met Kejriwal around 2003. He was then an IRS officer who had taken a sabbatical to start an NGO, Parivartan, which was involved in the RTI campaign. We were addressing a seminar together in Lucknow and I found him totally committed to the cause, with a vast knowledge on the subject. 'The media must partner us in spreading the RTI message,' he told me then. I guess he was always keenly aware of media power, but little did I foresee that the bright, energetic IITian in a white shirt, black trousers and chappals would one day become a national figure. Not even when he won a Magsaysay in 2006 for his RTI work.

We kept in touch—NGOs are a valuable source of stories. In February 2011, Kejriwal came to us with another story idea, this time along with IPS officer Dr Kiran Bedi. The duo were offering to be part of our citizen journalism show on CNN-IBN where we focused on corruption that affected people's daily lives. 'We are starting a signature campaign to push for a Jan Lok Pal and need your support,' said Kejriwal. We readily agreed to shoot a story with Kejriwal and Dr Bedi pitching for an anti-corruption ombudsman. But I had a note of caution. 'Please remember, television is a visual medium. Signature campaigns may not be effective on TV unless backed up by a story that catches the eye.'